

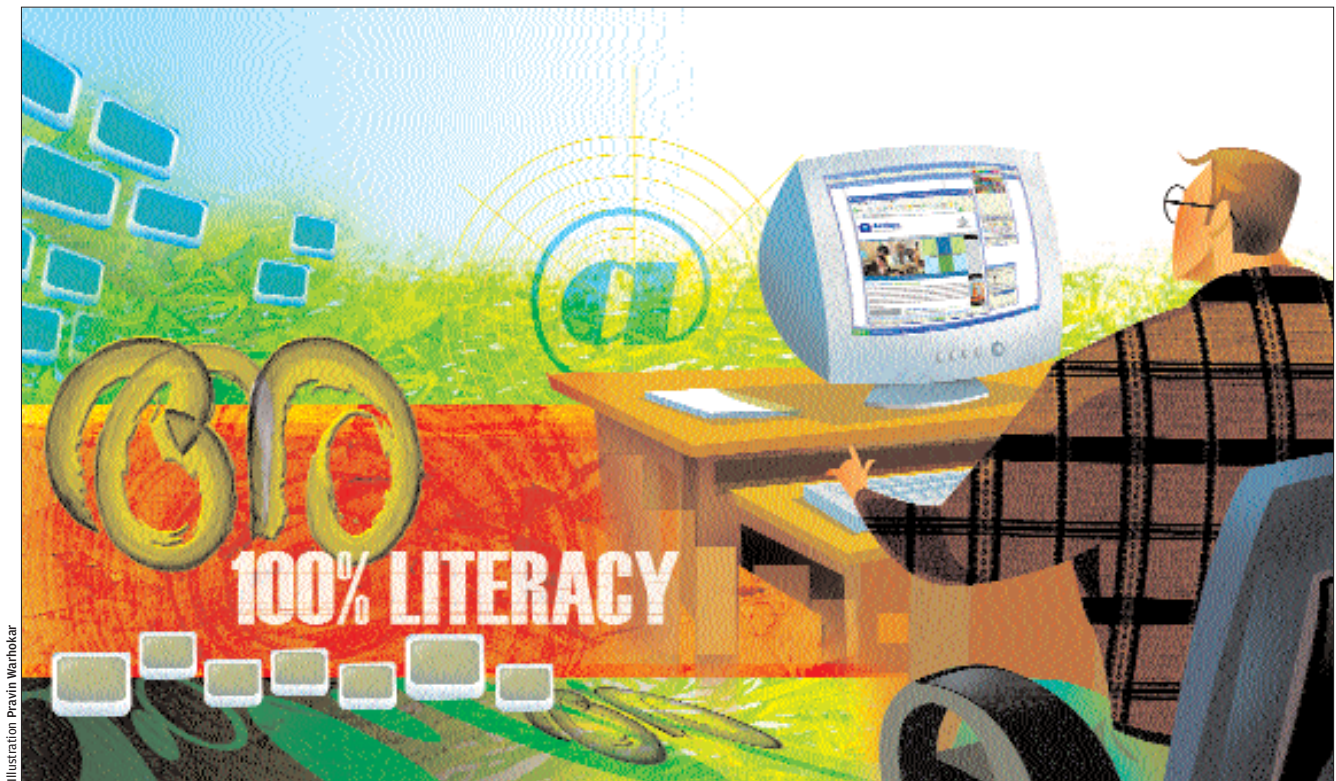


Illustration Pravin Warhokar

Completely Internet Literate

God's own country gave India its first 100 per cent e-literate district

Samir Makwana

“No need to write letters... no telephone required... now I can see their faces and talk with them. It's like having them right in this room,” says eighty-three-year-old farmer Mohammed Kutty Haji, Marakkara Gram Panchayat. He got to the fourth standard as a kid, and now comfortably chats with his son and grandson who live in a Gulf



Chatting with a grandson in the Gulf: M K Haji of Malappuram

country—after receiving e-literacy training.

Many people like him enjoy the facilities of video chatting, video counselling, e-mails, and more at the many Akshaya e-Kendras.

The Akshaya e-Kendras are one-stop information and e-services kiosks, established in Malappuram district under the Akshaya Project. This project is the ICT (Information and Communications Technology) for Development Project, part of the Kerala State IT Mission. It was launched to provide e-governance and other related utility services to general citizens. The project piloted at Malappuram with a different take—“to bridge the digital divide,” by making residents of the district computer-literate.

The objectives of the project were to ensure rural connectivity through broadband-based Internet and intranet access, to provide basic computer literacy, and make local language e-con-

tent such as agri-business information and educational CDs available throughout the state. The project also focuses on promoting rural and youth entrepreneurship through ICT.

The Akshaya Project has won several awards for its implementation of IT, e-governance, and other facilities in the rural sector, effectively bridging the digital divide.

A Brief Profile

On 18 November, 2002, at Thiruvananthapuram, the Akshaya Project was launched by the President, Dr A P J Abdul Kalam. The project was piloted at Malappuram district north Kerala. In the first phase of this project, the target was, through an e-literacy program and providing basic computer training, to make 6.5 lakh people computer literate—one person from each household. The e-literacy training, which means providing basic computer operating exposure, would be provided at computer centres called